Abortion Poetry

by Ally Sheedy and Gwendolyn Brooks

Local Anesthesia by Ally Sheedy

I had an abortion yesterday.

At 11:53 A.M. across from Central Park.

You know where it is.

Near F.A.O. Schwarz and the Plaza Hotel.

At the clinic.

I was awake for the whole thing cause

I wanted to remember it.

There was a Snoopy poster on the ceiling.

It said "Smile."

INTRODUCTION

Nearly 40 percent of teen pregnancies end in abortion. Many of these teen mothers feel a sense of relief that the ordeal is over. And, certainly, it is possible to continue with life without peers even knowing that a fellow teenager was pregnant. However, many teenagers find themselves feeling a sense of remorse later down the road. The idea that a life was terminated at a teen's discretion can be an emotionally traumatic experience.

Local Anesthesia by Ally Sheedy

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Today I frown by the trophy case

and watch Laura go over her algebra homework.

No one in this school knows where I was.

Today I am just in class

and everyone is impossibly young.

They scraped my insides out.

There's a burning feeling between my legs

so I keep them crossed

and no one will know.

I'm a "fallen woman."

I'm not gonna lie to you.

I didn't want the kid.

This is not one of those songs about

the abortion blues.

I'm just sorry I had to

put myself

through it.

I didn't get my algebra homework done.

Not even close.

I was so scared about this ordeal

I spent the weekend on the suicide line.

"Hello," said a woman's voice.

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"Do you need help?"

I wept.

"I'm so scared," I cried. "They're going to cut me up. They'll
tear me apart like tissue paper,
like spider webs, like bread.
It's not my fault. Do you understand?"

I put my forehead against the glass trophy case.
It is cool here.
We have so many swimming trophies
for a New York City school.
I wish I could shake him off me.
Not the guy. You know. Him.
The kid.
I know how hard he clutched me
from the inside
when they took him out.
Now he dances bodiless
tapping round my head
like rain.
I know you, he says. You are my mom.

The hallways are empty and Laura went to class.
It's 12:22. He's been dead for over 24 hours.

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I double over. Sick.

You don't know me, I say back to him.
I am an algebra student.
You don't know me.
I am someone's daughter.
You don't know me, baby.
I am a doper,
a compulsive liar,
I don't have a boyfriend,
never get picked for the basketball team.
I am sixteen.
Is this who you want for your mother?
I know you, he says back.
You're mine.
And yeah, I guess. I know.
I conceived this tyrant New Year's Eve
at the Hilton Hotel.
I knew it when it happened and that it was a boy.
I've read about this before in corny short fiction.
You know, in magazines like *Complete Woman.*
But it happened like a bolt
of electric lightning.
I felt it and I knew.

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I'm a mother.

He - the guy - went out to the deli
and I looked out the window at the pouring rain.
I knelt there naked at 2:39 A.M.
and offered myself to the rhythm outside.
Wet New York City.
Happy New Year, rest of my life.
What am I going to do with the kid?
I was awake for my abortion
Because I wanted to remember it.
They put my legs in stirrups.
I was very still.

I looked up at the Snoopy on the ceiling
and prayed.
I'm letting you go, I said to the boy.
This is the way out.

The guy in the other room
who split the cost with me
is sleeping with my best friend.
He hopes we get done in time
to catch the 3: 15 movie at Loew's.
Superman.

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All morning he cried 'cause he's a Catholic.
And I rocked him and told him, It's all right.
Later today he'll push against me hard
in the bathroom
and I'll let him
even though I'm bruised inside from ribs to thighs.

It was in the pamphlet-
Sex now can rip you open.
I read it, but I know they only meant
physically.

I need someone to hold me tightly so much.

So, you see, baby,
I'm giving you the way out.
I'm your mother and I want you to take it.
It's the only thing I'll ever tell you to do.
So, listen.

I was awake for my abortion because
I wanted to feel him leave me.
I wanted him to know why.
I did it 'cause I'm sixteen and
a compulsive liar.
I did it 'cause I need to be held too much

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and I'm not a Catholic.
I did it because I don't have a father for you
and have only my body to give.
I have learned that this is not enough.

I was awake at 11:53 A.M. yesterday
for my abortion.
Undeveloped
Unevolved
one thing alone is clear
and it's my incompleteness.
Emotionally I know myself to be
the real fetus.

Silently repeating this I lay
and they took him out.
The only choice I knew
I could make.

When it was over I lay so still
they thought I was in shock.
But I was only saying good-bye
To him.
And you never can.

'Cause, child, I hear you in my head

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and on you cry like rain
and I can feel you at my heart
inside I nurse you still.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Ally Sheedy
Book: Yesterday I Saw the Sun
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TRANSITION

Teen pregnancies are not the only ones who result in a high rate of abortions. In "The Mother" by Gwendolyn Brooks the speaker mourns the loss of children aborted because of the poverty of the mother. Her desire to do what was best for her children and the finality of her decisions. The depiction of the narrator—honest, reflective, and self-aware— show a clear conflict between her desire to do what was best for her children and the finality of her decisions. The narrator is complicated—full of conflicting emotions regarding both herself and her lost children.

The Mother by Gwendolyn Brooks

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The Mother by Gwendolyn Brooks

Abortions will not let you forget.
You remember the children you got that you did not get,
The damp small pulps with a little or with no hair,
The singers and workers that never handled the air.
You will never neglect or beat
Them, or silence or buy with a sweet.
You will never wind up the sucking-thumb
Or scuttle off ghosts that come.
You will never leave them, controlling your luscious sigh,
Return for a snack of them, with gobbling mother-eye.

I have heard in the voices of the wind the voices of my dim killed children.
I have contracted. I have eased
My dim dears at the breasts they could never suck.
I have said, Sweets, if I sinned, if I seized
Your luck
And your lives from your unfinished reach,
If I stole your births and your names,
Your straight baby tears and your games,
Your stilted or lovely loves, your tumults, your marriages, aches, and your deaths,

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If I poisoned the beginnings of your breaths,
Believe that even in my deliberateness I was not deliberate.
Though why should I whine,
Whine that the crime was other than mine?—
Since anyhow you are dead.
Or rather, or instead,
You were never made.
But that too, I am afraid,
Is faulty: oh, what shall I say, how is the truth to be said?
You were born, you had body, you died.
It is just that you never giggled or planned or cried.

Believe me, I loved you all.
Believe me, I knew you, though faintly, and I loved,
I loved you
All.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Gwendolyn Brooks
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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
IL State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

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